AI in Global Governance: The Attention–Legitimacy Tradeoff for International Organizations

Allison Carnegie, Seowoo Chung, and Lisa Fan*

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Abstract

International organizations (IOs) need legitimacy to perform their mandates, but they also compete for public attention in an increasingly crowded information environment. This paper argues that artificial intelligence creates an attention–legitimacy tradeoff for global governance. On the one hand, AI can make IOs appear innovative, modern, and capable of addressing complex problems, thereby increasing public engagement. On the other hand, AI can undermine legitimacy because many people associate it with opacity, elite control, and weak accountability. We evaluate this argument using an original survey experiment and novel social media data. In the experiment, respondents are less supportive of IOs when those organizations emphasize their use of AI. In the observational analysis of IO Twitter posts from 2012 to 2023, however, tweets referencing AI generate greater engagement than otherwise similar posts. Our findings show that AI can increase the visibility of international organizations while eroding trust in them, creating a key tension as IOs seek to navigate the evolving global governance landscape.

Keywords: international organizations; social media; global governance; emerging technology; artificial intelligence

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*Allison Carnegie is Professor, Columbia University (Email: allison.carnegie@columbia.edu). Seowoo Chung is PhD Candidate, Columbia University. Lisa Fan is postdoctoral researcher, University of Oxford. We received helpful comments from Richard Clark and the participants of virtual APSA. All remaining errors are our own.

International organizations (IOs) across the globe are increasingly turning to artificial intelligence to pursue their mandates. Health-oriented IOs use AI to forecast hospital bed occupancy, estimate drug needs, and improve vaccine allocation.[1] Peace and security organizations use AI to support drone-based medical deliveries and strengthen monitoring and surveillance (Omar 2023). Across issue areas, IOs are under growing pressure to modernize, and AI is often viewed as a tool that can make global governance more efficient, more responsive, and more capable of addressing complex transnational problems.

Yet the spread of AI in global governance raises the question of how AI shapes public reactions to international organizations. This question matters because IOs depend on public legitimacy and social acceptance for their continued relevance and vitality (Dellmuth, Scholte and Tallberg 2019). Citizens influence whether governments sustain funding for and participation in international cooperation, as well as whether interventions are accepted, implemented, and trusted. If publics view AI-assisted governance as untrustworthy, unaccountable, or imposed from above, IOs may face greater resistance just as they are trying to present themselves as more effective and adaptable. AI thus may help IOs appear more relevant while simultaneously making them appear less legitimate.

This tension is especially important in a moment when many IOs face increasing skepticism and backlash (Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019). Indeed, existing research shows that public confidence in international institutions is mixed and often fragile (Brutger and Clark 2022). The turn toward AI could complicate attitudes further, potentially cutting in two different directions. On the one hand, AI may deepen existing concerns about distance, opacity, and elite control in global governance. People may worry that algorithms make high-stakes decisions without sufficient human oversight, create bias and misinformation (Kreps, McCain and Brundage 2022; Kreps 2020; Ternovski, Kalla and Aronow 2022), or weaken democratic accountability (Kreps and Kriner 2023). If so, AI could intensify perceptions that IOs are technocratic and detached from the people affected by their decisions (Carnegie, Clark and Zucker 2024).

[1]"Harnessing Artifical Intelligence for Health." World Health Organization. 2026.

On the other hand, AI may offer IOs a powerful signal of competence and innovation, and attract notice even among detractors. IOs are often criticized for being slow, inefficient, or unable to solve urgent global problems. By incorporating AI, they may appear more capable and better equipped to deliver concrete benefits. If citizens believe AI can reduce costs or increase the effectiveness of interventions, they may view IOs more favorably for instrumental reasons despite potential moral reservations about the technology itself. Even if citizens distrust AI, the technology may help IOs project a modern image in a crowded informational environment where organizations must compete for relevance as well as legitimacy (Gehring and Faude 2014; Voeten 2016; Clark 2021).

We argue that these dynamics create an attention–legitimacy tradeoff for international organizations. AI can increase the visibility of IOs by signaling novelty and problem-solving capabilities, but also undermines trust if publics associate AI with opacity, bias, or weak accountability. Put differently, AI may improve engagement while harming legitimacy. This framework helps make sense of why IOs might still incorporate and publicize their use of AI even if publics remain skeptical: IOs seek to remain relevant and efficacious, even at the risk of triggering distrust.

To evaluate this argument, we combine experimental and observational evidence. First, we field an original survey experiment that varies whether an IO incorporates AI into its work. This allows us to identify whether AI use reduces IO legitimacy and to examine whether any opposition to IOs reflects moral concerns, instrumental calculations, or both. Second, we analyze original social media data from IO Twitter accounts between 2012 and 2023. Here, we examine whether posts that emphasize AI attract greater public attention and engagement than otherwise similar posts that do not. Taken together, these two analyses allow us to distinguish between trust and attention: publics may react negatively to AI when asked for their evaluations of IOs, yet still pay more attention when IOs publicly emphasize their use of the technology.

Our findings support the existence of this tension. In the survey experiment, respondents are less supportive of IOs when those organizations emphasize AI. In the social media analysis, however, posts highlighting AI receive greater engagement. We further validate this using a large language model to classify AI tweets by type, showing that engagement effects are largest for tweets describing operational AI use. AI, then, appears to make IOs more salient without making them more trusted. The political consequences of emerging technologies for global governance are therefore more complex than standard accounts imply. As IOs navigate the adoption of AI, they must trade-off the visibility gains with the decline in public legitimacy.

The paper makes several scholarly contributions. First, it adds to growing scholarship on technology and global governance. Existing work has examined when IOs adopt new technologies (Milner and Solstad 2021), how they shape new technologies (Cheng and Ge 2024), and how emerging tools are regulated (Frieden and Silve 2023; Chaudoin and Mangini 2022), but we know much less about how citizens react when IOs use these tools. Yet this is a crucial question because the political consequences of technological change depend on whether publics accept or contest their adoption.

Second, the paper contributes to research on IO legitimacy. A large literature asks what makes international organizations appear legitimate in the eyes of citizens.[2] We extend that research by showing that technological innovation may not uniformly strengthen an IO's image. Instead, AI can create a tradeoff between appearing capable and appearing trustworthy. Understanding that tension is essential for explaining how IOs navigate technological change and for assessing whether new tools ultimately strengthen or weaken the legitimacy of international cooperation.

Third, we further the literature that treats international organizations as strategic actors (Stone 2011; Copelovitch 2010). We demonstrate that IOs do not passively absorb new technologies but are comprised of individuals who manage a tradeoff between visibility and legitimacy. While existing work studies IO communication extensively, we know less about how emerging technologies alter IO's strategic calculations. We argue that IOs face trade-offs when adopting new technologies that differ from member states, as it is shaped by their unique position in global governance and their resulting constraints.

[2]E.g., Dellmuth, Scholte and Tallberg (2019).

IOs, Public Attention, and the Promise of AI

IOs act in an “economy of attention" where being noticed can be valuable for their continued existence and relevance (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2025; Hofferberth 2023). At the organizational level, attention helps IOs show that they are relevant in a crowded governance environment. Recent work on IO communication argues that IOs increasingly use social media to reach citizens directly because they operate in a competitive environment (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2025) where visibility can support recognition and broader legitimation efforts. Communication departments, in particular, are tasked with making IOs familiar to fragmented audiences and with navigating the tradeoff between neutral information provision and more persuasive advocacy (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2025).

At the bureaucratic level, attention can matter because it impacts bureaucratic autonomy and influence within IOs (Carpenter and Krause 2012). Bureaucrats want recognition to further their careers and help them manage the day-to-day operations of these organizations (Weaver 2008). IO bureaucrats exert an independent effect on IOs (Heinzel, Weaver and Jorgensen 2024; Cormier and Manger 2021; Heinzel and Liese 2021), much like bureaucrats in organizations more generally (Jost 2023; Carcelli 2023), and attention can help promote their own efforts and talents.

Bureaucrats may also seek to control the narrative because they may anticipate reputational damage otherwise (Erlich et al. 2021). Attention can help them combat the intense pressure they face from detractors. Public contestation of IOs has become more visible, and communication has become more fragmented. Many organizations face tighter budgets, rising demands, and criticism that they are too slow, remote, or bureaucratic to solve urgent cross-border problems. Populists, nationalists, and others frequently use their communication channels to disparage IOs and to blame them for their countries’ problems. Using slogans like “America First," they argue that globalists and global governance are responsible for many of the issues that society faces today. Bureaucrats may seek to fight off these claims using their own methods of communication, and require attention to do so (Carnegie, Clark and Fan 2024).

That logic extends to IO leaders and staff. Leaders of IOs often want to leave a mark in line with their ideologies (Copelovitch and Rickard 2021), expand the organization’s perceived relevance, and strengthen their own standing as effective global problem-solvers. Officials and staff can also benefit when their organization becomes associated with salient new issues: visibility can increase internal influence, justify budget claims, attract external partners, and help individuals build policy reputations as experts on emerging topics. Indeed, international bureaucracies strategically cultivate ties and use information provision to strengthen their reputation within policy regimes (Mederake et al. 2022).

However, these actors often face an uphill battle in gaining attention, as publics often have limited direct knowledge of IOs (Dellmuth et al. 2021). Compared with national governments, IOs seem distant, technocratic, and less visible in everyday politics, so many people lack detailed knowledge about international organizations and policies (Sungmin Rho and Michael Tomz 2016). The public-opinion literature on IOs shows that because IOs operate in low-information environments, legitimacy beliefs are shaped under conditions of limited knowledge, often by cues from elites and public discourse (Dellmuth and Tallberg 2023). That said, IOs can become highly salient during crises or moments of politicization, such as the IMF during financial crises, the WTO during trade conflicts, the UN in war and peace crises, or the WHO during pandemics. In those moments, citizens are more able to connect IOs to real-world outcomes and to form stronger views about them (Schlipphak, Meiners and Kiratli 2022), so they can represent useful opportunities for IOs to shape broader narratives.

Thus, both to capture attention proactively and in response to challenges, IOs have "gone public" (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018). Many organizations have expanded their outreach beyond diplomats to include journalists, experts, activists, and ordinary citizens, and have professionalized and centralized their communication departments in order to disseminate messages strategically and evaluate their effects (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2018). Platforms such as X, Facebook, and Instagram represent integral parts of IO communication strategy, as IOs maintain official institutional accounts, and supplement them with the accounts of senior leaders and officials (Özdemir and Rauh 2022; Krzyżanowski 2020; Bouchard 2020). Social media represents a low-cost platform that allows for rapid dissemination and direct access to diverse audiences (Ecker-Ehrhardt 2025), helping IOs appear closer to the “common man" by using more accessible language, visuals, and direct outreach (Carnegie, Clark and Fan 2024).

In this fight for attention, promoting AI usage can help IOs in several ways. First, people pay attention to AI because it is framed as a major general-purpose technology with potentially wide effects across work, health, education, security, and politics. It has become a highly salient public issue, attracting widespread media attention and sustained public debate about its societal risks and benefits. People often see AI scenarios as both likely and consequential, even when they also believe they are risky or undesirable (Winkel 2025). Indeed, AI may be particularly effective at generating attention because it attracts engagement even from skeptics. Most IO communication strategies including moral appeals, expert testimony, and crisis messaging work best when audiences are already sympathetic. AI, by contrast, is salient partly because it is controversial (Winkel 2025). This makes AI a powerful attention signal in a fragmented information environment, capable of producing engagement without requiring prior support for either the technology or the organization deploying it.

Second, AI can signal that an IO is innovative and capable. When an organization says it is using AI, audiences can infer that it is modern, technologically advanced, and trying to solve problems in new ways, even if people are unsure whether they approve. People do not need to understand the technical details in order to grasp this message, making it accessible and salient. This is helpful in a crowded institutional landscape (Morse and Keohane 2014; Henning and Pratt 2020; Drezner 2009; Keohane and Victor 2011; Gehring and Faude 2014; Raustiala and Victor 2004; Alter and Meunier 2009),[3] where IOs want to avoid appearing slow, outdated, or irrelevant (Sidhu et al. 2024). Thus, since IOs are already using AI across a wide range of activities, they face considerable incentives to promote these efforts.

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[3]While IOs can use other methods to attract attention as well, we view AI usage as complementary to these efforts.

IOs, Legitimacy, and the Risk of AI

While attention is helpful to IOs, they also need legitimacy. The legitimacy literature defines this as the belief that an organization's authority is appropriately exercised, and it treats legitimacy as crucial for whether IOs can govern effectively and sustain authority over time. Tallberg and Zürn (2019)'s framework places legitimacy at the center of global governance because IOs increasingly depend not only on state consent but also on public acceptance. Related work shows that citizens and elites vary considerably in how legitimate they find IOs (Dellmuth et al. 2021), and that these beliefs matter politically (Dellmuth et al. 2022).[4] When legitimacy erodes, IOs face contestation, resistance, and the risk that states disengage, exit, or shift support to alternative institutional arrangements (von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2019; Schneider and Urpelainen 2013; von Borzyskowski and Vabulas 2025; Weaver 2008).

Because legitimacy is so valuable, IOs, like other bureaucracies (Carpenter 2014), actively try to cultivate it. IOs seek favorable opinion through public outreach, symbolic appeals, and narratives designed to present their authority as justified (Carnegie, Clark and Fan 2024). IOs may do so, for example, by relying on democratic legitimation narratives (Dingwerth, Schmidtke and Weise 2020), and emphasizing participation, inclusion, and responsiveness (Dingwerth, Schmidtke and Weise 2020). Institutions have thus become increasingly attentive to reputation management and public-facing communication to bolster support.

Yet IOs face considerable challenges in bolstering their legitimacy. IOs already exercise their authority at a distance, as they are weakly connected to electoral publics, depend on professional expertise, and are widely viewed as too technocratic and difficult to hold accountable (Ghassim 2024). AI can further exacerbate these negative perceptions, since citizens often distrust AI (Kreps et al. 2023), particularly in public decision-making because they associate it with opacity, bias, weak accountability, and democratic loss. AI can therefore help IOs get noticed while making them seem less legitimate—what we call the attention-legitimacy tradeoff. That is the core tension

[4] Opinions may depend in part on views of member states (Johnson 2011).

motivating our argument.

AI may erode IO legitimacy by worsening exactly the dimensions on which publics already worry about global governance: democratic control, impartiality, transparency, and accountability. Indeed, IO legitimacy depends not just on whether an organization appears effective, but also on whether its authority is exercised in ways citizens regard as fair and impartial (Dellmuth et al. 2022). AI may help IOs project competence, but it can also make them look less procedurally legitimate.

One reason is that AI can make IOs appear less democratic. A recurring concern in the broader AI-and-politics literature is that algorithmic systems shift decisions away from visible, contestable human judgment and toward technical systems that ordinary citizens cannot meaningfully monitor or challenge. AI can weaken civic agency and complicate accountability, since legitimacy depends on decision rules and oversight opportunities (Starke and Lünich 2020). For IOs, which already face criticism for being distant from ordinary citizens (van der Veer and Onderco 2026), adding AI may worsen these concerns.

AI may also erode legitimacy because many view it as biased and unfair.[5] The political appeal of AI often rests on the promise that it is neutral or data-driven, but AI systems can reproduce or amplify existing biases embedded in training data, design choices, and implementation contexts. Public support for AI government depends on fairness perceptions, and citizens are less supportive when they worry that AI will produce unequal outcomes. For IOs, that is especially costly because legitimacy depends in part on being seen as impartial across countries and populations (Tallberg and Zürn 2019). If publics suspect that AI systems favor powerful states or private firms, then AI use can undermine an IO's neutrality.

Another concern is that AI can make IOs appear more technocratic. Many IOs are already seen as expert-driven institutions insulated from everyday democratic control (Ghassim 2024). AI can exacerbate this perception because it adds difficult to understand technology on top of technocratic

[5]"Study finds perceived political bias in popular AI models." Stanford Report. May 21, 2025.

expertise. AI may thus make these organizations look even more like specialized bodies that ordinary citizens cannot evaluate. AI can therefore reinforce the “rule by experts" critique that populists and other critics already direct at global governance (Starke and Lünich 2020).

Finally, AI may undermine an IO’s legitimacy because it often appears opaque and weakly accountable. A large literature treats transparency and accountability as critical to global governance (Tørstad 2024), yet as central challenges in AI governance (de Fine Licht and de Fine Licht 2020). Citizens may distrust AI use in IOs if they cannot understand how decisions are made, who is responsible when errors occur, or how affected people can contest outcomes. For IOs, this is especially serious because they already face questions about who can sanction them, how representative they are, and how they justify their decisions. AI can exacerbate each of these concerns.

These two logics generate distinct predictions. The attention logic predicts that IO communication promoting AI use will attract greater public engagement, signaling novelty and competence in a crowded information environment. At the same time, the legitimacy logic suggests that concerns about opacity, bias, and accountability will dampen public support for such IOs. We therefore expect the incorporation of AI to increase public attention while decreasing public legitimacy, generating the attention-legitimacy tradeoff we theorize.

Empirical Analysis

We test these expectations using two complementary research designs. First, a survey experiment assesses whether emphasizing AI reduces public support for an IO and worsens perceptions of fairness and elitism. Second, an observational analysis of IO social media communication evaluates whether messages referencing AI attract greater public engagement. Taken together, these designs allow us to evaluate the legitimacy and attention components of our key tradeoff.

Experimental Test of IO's AI Incorporation on IO Support

We first assess whether IOs' employment of AI technology increases support for their operations among citizens of member states. To do so, we conducted a survey experiment in the United States. The United States represents a primary funder of many IOs and often retains disproportionate influence in these bodies (Broz 2008; Copelovitch 2010; Stone 2011; Clark and Dolan 2021), and thus it is particularly important for IOs to obtain the support of U.S. citizens. The U.S. is also the preeminent developer of AI, so the opinions of U.S. citizens are especially relevant.

We recruited 2,000 respondents using Amazon Mechanical Turk (mTurk), which offers a convenience sample of Americans; the survey was administered through Qualtrics. Though mTurk is not representative of the U.S. population, we oversampled conservative respondents to obtain a relatively balanced sample with respect to political ideology; around 40 percent of respondents identify as Democrats and 40 percent as Republicans in our sample. We also took several steps to ensure a quality respondent pool including using Virtual Private Server screening to confirm that respondents are located in the United States, implementing a basic attention check, and eliminating respondents who provided low-quality or nonsensical responses.

Our experiment provided respondents with information about a hypothetical development organization — the International Development Fund (IDF). We opted for a hypothetical organization because doing so allows us to control the information that respondents have about the organization. When treating respondents using real organizations, a common problem is that some respondents may know a good deal about the IO's operations and mission, while others may not have heard of the organization before the survey. The use of a hypothetical organization ensures that respondents operate on a level playing field. Our approach also builds on recent work highlighting the potential benefits of abstraction in survey design (Brutger et al. 2022).[6]

Our control group received a hypothetical mandate for the IDF, which was modeled closely

[6]The authors specifically find that situational hypotheticality does not substantively change results, though added context can dampen treatment effects.

after the missions of influential development IOs like the World Bank and the African Development Bank. The control text read as follows: "The International Development Fund (IDF) is an organization of 190 countries, working with developing countries to reduce poverty and achieve sustainable growth by financing investment, mobilizing capital in international financial markets, and providing advisory services to businesses and governments."

To determine if AI usage influences domestic publics when employed by IOs, our treatment condition portrays the IDF as incorporating AI. In addition to the mandate described above, respondents in this treatment were told the following about the IDF: "The IDF recently adopted new artificial intelligence technology which will be used in many tasks such as generating policy recommendations for recipient countries. It will likely replace many of the expert economists on staff." We choose this framing because it reflects real patterns of AI adoption in international bureaucracies and organizations, where AI is increasingly depicted as a substitute for human expertise rather than a complement. In the context of global governance, the staff in question are distant international bureaucrats rather than domestic workers, making it less likely that respondents react mainly out of concern for employment loss. Instead, the replacement cue strengthens a broader concern central to our theory: that AI may displace visible human expertise and heighten perceptions of elitism, opacity, and reduced accountability in IO decision-making.

We utilized two questions to capture respondent support for the IO, in line with existing work (Bearce and Scott 2018; Zvobgo 2019; Brutger and Clark 2022). The first question measures approval of the IDF on a five-point scale from "Strongly disapprove" to "Strongly approve" in response to the following question: "How much do you approve or disapprove of U.S. participation in the International Development Fund?" The second assesses the extent to which respondents believe the IDF is fair, asking them, "To what extent do you perceive the mission and objectives of the International Development Fund to be fair?" Again, they responded on a five-point scale, ranging from "Not fair at all" to "Very fair."[7] Note that our use of a U.S. sample makes this a hard test of our theory since the IDF is not likely to place strong constraints on the U.S. relative to

[7]Perceptions of fairness are closely linked to legitimacy (Buchanan and Keohane 2006; Dell-

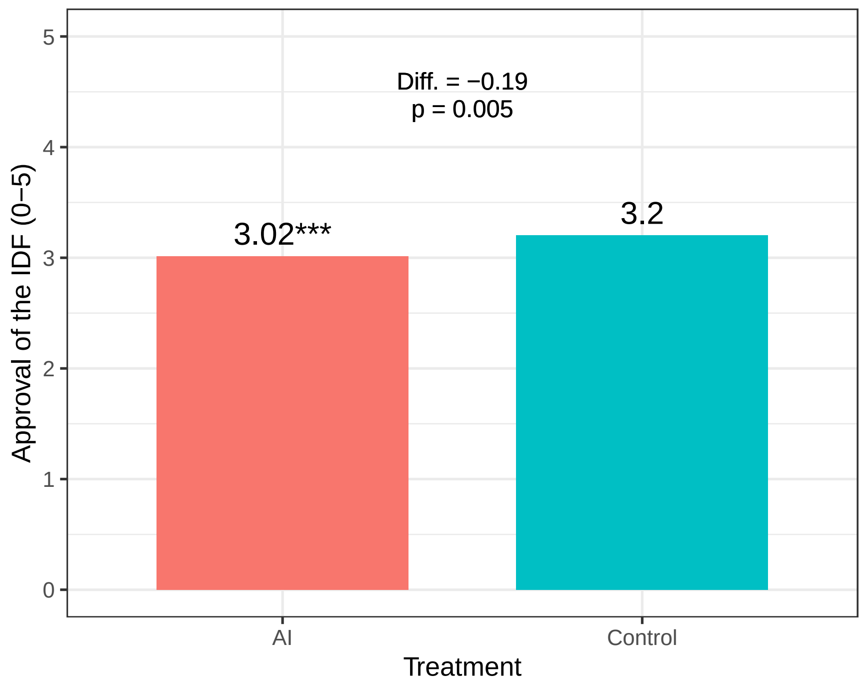

Figure 1: **Approval of the IDF by Treatment Condition.** Average approval of the IDF by treatment condition. Statistical significance is denoted with respect to the control condition as determined by a two-tailed t-test.

recipient countries.

We start by examining the simple difference-in-means across our conditions. The results for the approval and fairness DVs can be found in Figures 1–2 respectively. In line with our theory, we find that adding AI to an IO's functioning reduces support for the IO. On a five-point scale, the exposure to the incorporation of AI by the IDF decreases individuals' approvals of the organization by 0.19, or around 18% of the standard deviation. The same treatment also lowered perceptions of the IDF's fairness by 0.17, or around 16% of the standard deviation.

In order to better understand individuals' responses to the incorporation of artificial intelligence in IOs, we also measured the extent to which individuals perceived the IDF to be an elitist organization on a five-point scale, asking the following question: "To what extent do you perceive the IDF to be an elitist organization?" Also in line with our theory, we find that the incorporation

muth 2018).

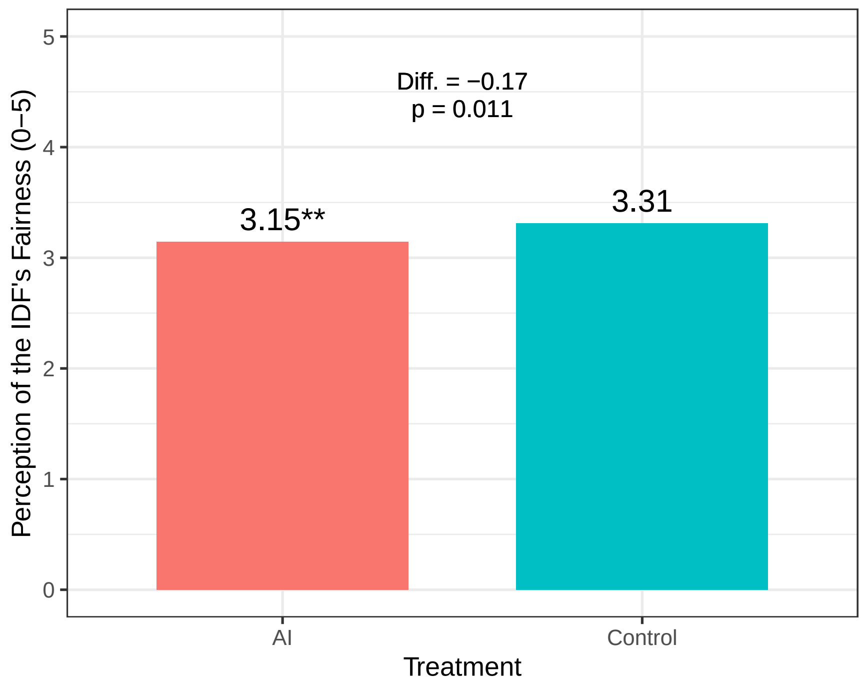

Figure 2: **Perceived Fairness of the IDF by Treatment Condition.** Average perceived fairness of the IDF by treatment group. Statistical significance is denoted with respect to the control condition as determined by a two-tailed t-test.

of artificial intelligence raises individuals' perceptions of the IO as elitist. The magnitude of this increase surmounts to around 15% of the standard deviation in the outcome.

Next, we explore possible heterogeneity in the treatment effect. Figure 4 plots the effects of AI incorporation on approval of the IDF. The top estimate reflects the average effect of the AI treatment, and the remaining estimates investigate whether the effects of the treatment systematically vary for certain subgroups of respondents. Overall, we find a surprising consistency of effects across a range of possible moderating variables. Notably, the effects were similar among respondents who reported voting for President Trump in the 2020 election and those who did not, and among respondents who displayed high or low populist attitudes[8]. The results were also generally

[8]Individuals' levels of populist attitudes were calculated based their agreement with five populist statements adapted from (Akkerman, Mudde and Zaslove 2014). The five statements were: the politicians in Congress need to follow the will of the people; the people, not the politicians, should make our most important policy decisions; I'd rather be represented by an ordinary citizen

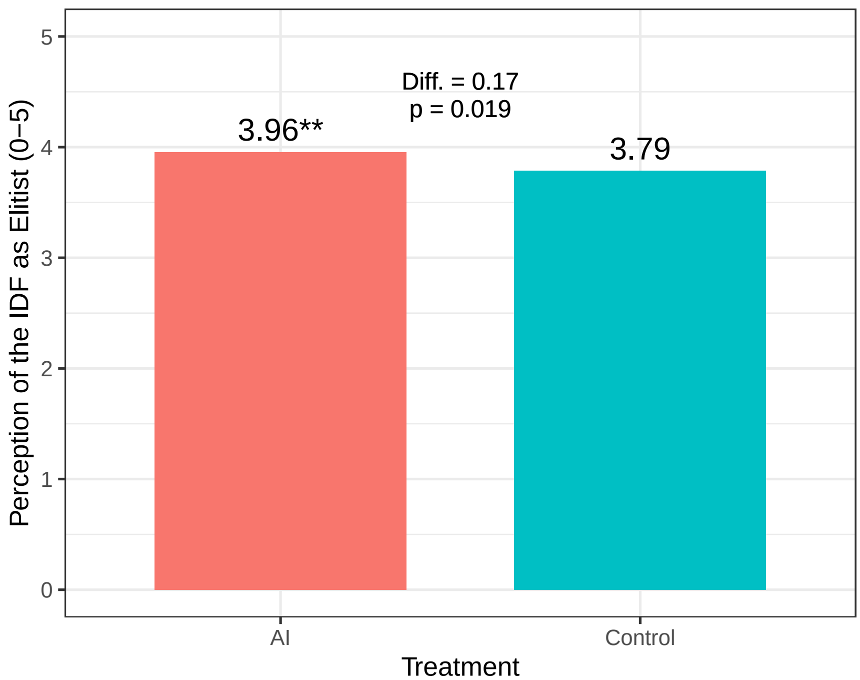

Figure 3: **Perceived Elitism of the IDF by Treatment Condition.** Average perceived elitism of the IDF by treatment group. Statistical significance is denoted with respect to the control condition as determined by a two-tailed t-test.

stable across gender, partisanship, education levels, and levels of cooperative internationalism.

Our findings demonstrate that the use of AI reduces public support for IOs and engenders a perception of increased elitism and reduced legitimacy among the public. This effect is consistently observed across various subgroups, including individuals who are not inherently predisposed towards populism or anti-IO sentiment. While our design does not allow us to adjudicate among mechanisms, the decline in perceptions of fairness is largely consistent with concerns about bias and impartiality, while the increase in perceptions of elitism map onto the technocracy concerns we theorize.

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than an experienced elite; the political differences between the people and the elite are larger than the differences among the people. Respondents were asked to rate their agreement on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

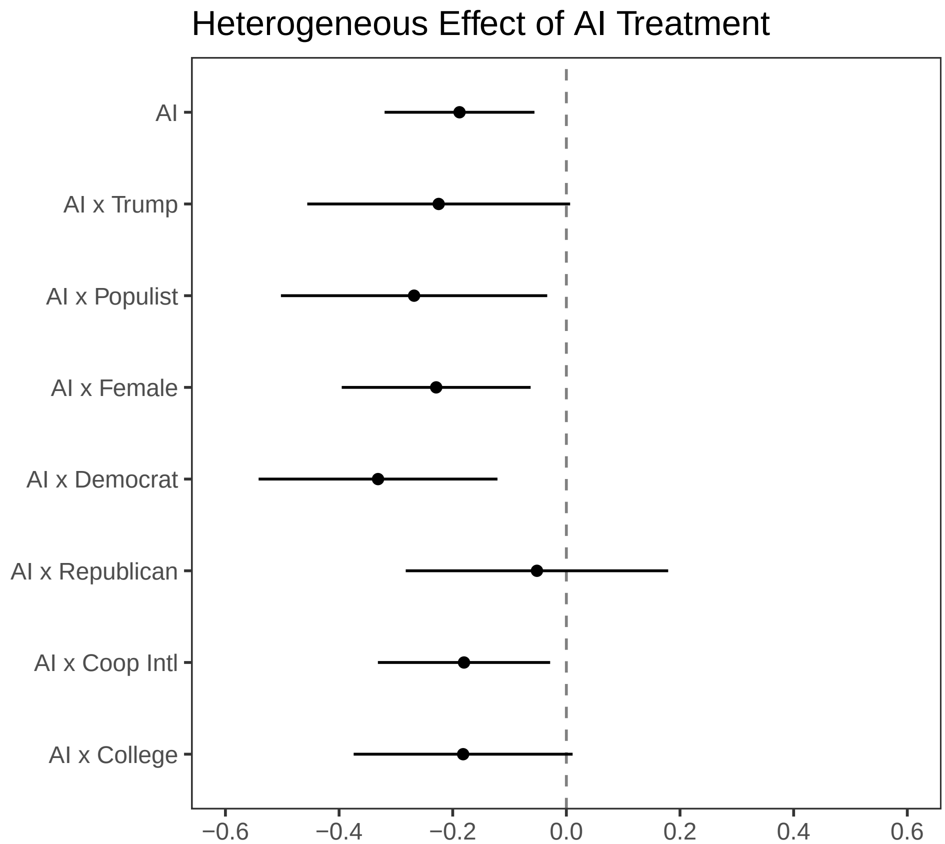

Figure 4: **Heterogeneous Effects of AI on the Approval of the IDF**. Effects of AI on the Approval of the IDF by subgroup. All effects are relative to the control condition. Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals are displayed for each treatment.

Twitter-Based Tests of IO's AI Incorporation and Engagement

Next, we evaluate our arguments using social media data to evaluate how the public reacts to IO messaging that incorporates AI. Specifically, we test whether tweets that mention the use of AI elicit greater engagement among users compared to tweets that do not. This analysis speaks to the attention component of the tradeoff, examining whether the publicized use of AI draws greater public attention in the everyday informational environments where IO communications occur.

We construct a novel dataset of tweets issued by the official accounts of 23 IOs from 2012 to 2023. Our dataset includes 492,524 tweets, excluding retweets, compiled using the TWITTER API FOR ACADEMIC RESEARCH. Our sample of IOs include a range of general purpose and task-specific global IOs. Additional details on our Twitter dataset is located in Appendix Table

A1. We focus on social media as an important form of IO communication. Social media presence among IOs has increased over recent years, with Twitter serving as the most popular forum.[9] Our data reveal that IOs maintain an active presence on Twitter, with the majority of IOs issuing more than 50 tweets per month. Social media provides a broader audience for IOs to reach compared to other forms of communication, such as press releases. Research shows that Twitter's user base is extensive, with nearly 23% of all online adults on Twitter, largely outside the U.S. (Desilver 2016).

To identify AI-related tweets, we search each tweet for a mention of AI using a dictionary that contains explicit references to artificial intelligence, as well as terms synonymous with AI. We drafted these dictionary terms based on close readings of how IOs have defined AI in their online documents. For example, the World Bank employs terms corresponding to AI such as data mining, neural networks, and machine learning (World Bank 2021). All dictionary terms are located in Table A2. Tweets that contain a term from the AI dictionary are coded as 1, while tweets that do not contain such terms are coded as 0. Examples of tweets that contain references to AI based on our dictionary are located in Table A3. We follow standard preprocessing procedures. All words are lowercased with numbers, punctuation, and stop words removed. Tweets that are not originally in English were translated using the GOOGLE TRANSLATE API.

Figure 5 reveals the proportion of tweets that mention AI across all IOs by year. On average, tweets that discuss AI constitute roughly less than 3% of all tweets issued in a given year. Importantly, our findings show that IOs' mention of AI corresponds with broader trends in the global advancement of AI. Evidence suggests that language and image recognition abilities of AI began to rapidly improve and out-compete human performance after 2015-2016 (Roser 2022). Figure A1 reveals the proportion of AI tweets issued per year by IO. While IOs may vary, our descriptive results show that IOs such as the OECD, ITU, ADB, and World Bank similarly begin to issue more AI-related tweets after 2016.

[9] https://www.twiplomacy.com/international-organisations-on-social-media-2017

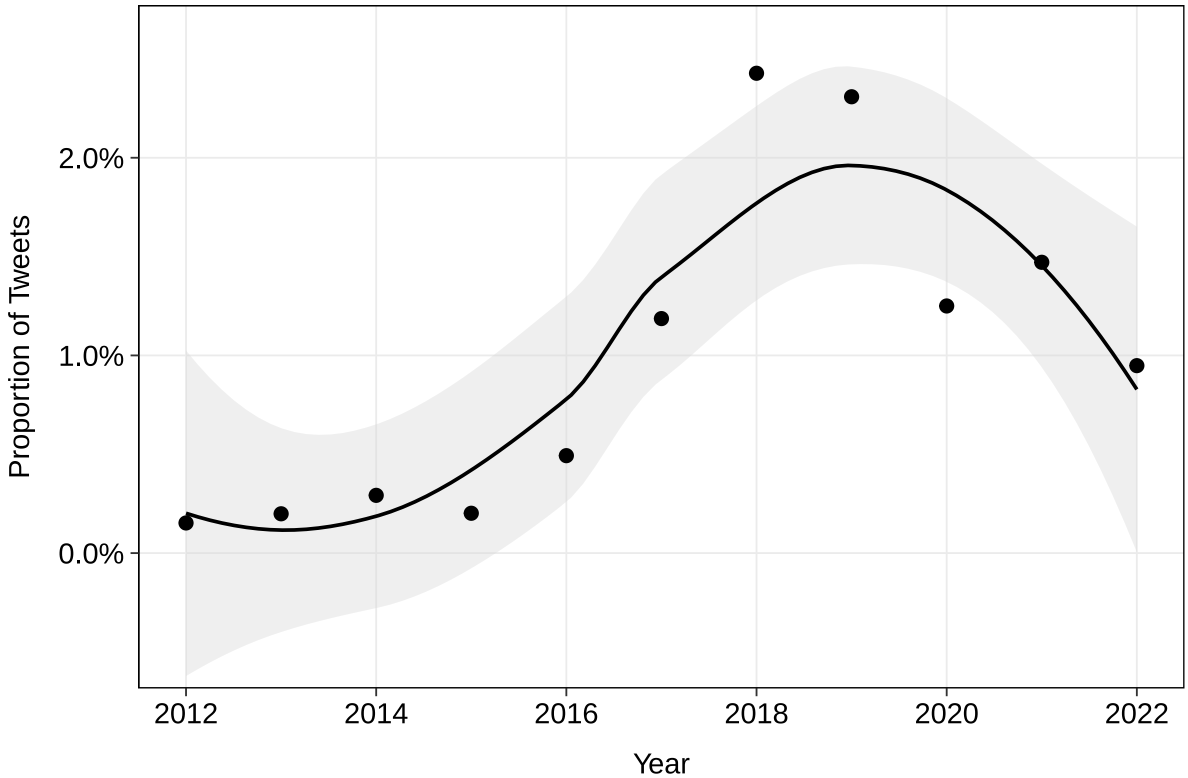

Figure 5: **Proportion of AI Tweets by Year.** Proportion of AI tweets issued by all IOs in the sample. Points represent yearly averages.

Twitter Engagement

Next, we use a nonparametric approach to compare whether tweets that mention AI receive greater engagement compared to similar tweets that do not mention AI (Ho et al. 2011). We match tweets based on covariates that might otherwise explain greater engagement including predicted topic, year, predicted probability of topic (binned), tweet author, sentiment score, and whether the tweet has a media attachment.[10] To label the topic of a given tweet, we fit a Structural Topic Model (Roberts et al. 2013; Roberts, Stewart and Tingley 2014) with $K = 30$. Tweets are represented using

[10]Sentiment is measured using the NRC Emotion Lexicon, a dictionary-based approach that scores words as positive or negative based on crowdsourced human judgments. We compute a net sentiment score for each tweet by subtracting negative word counts from positive word counts, normalized by tweet length, using the `syuzhet` package in R.

a 'bag-of-words' approach, which ignores the ordering of words, with all words lowercased and stemmed with numbers, punctuation, and stop words removed. General topics and their associated terms are listed in Appendix Figure A2. We then perform exact matching based on the covariates mentioned. Results in Figure A3 show relatively good covariate balance is achieved.

Using our matched data, we estimate OLS models with cluster-robust standard errors and year fixed effects, with the log number of likes and retweets as our primary outcomes. Results are located in Table 1. Columns 1–2 show that the mention of AI is positive and significant for both likes and retweets at the $p \leq 0.01$ level. Figure 6 further shows that tweets mentioning AI are associated with a roughly 10% increase in the number of likes received compared to tweets that do not mention AI. For retweets, we observe a 16% difference between tweets that mention AI and those that do not, consistent with the attention logic we theorize. These results are robust to the inclusion of month-year fixed effects, with coefficients of 0.094 for likes and 0.159 for retweets, both significant at the $p \leq 0.01$ level (see Appendix Table A4).

Table 1: Effect of AI Mention on Tweet Engagement (Exact-Matched Sample)

	Log (Likes) (1)	Log (Retweets) (2)
AI Mention	0.097***	0.153***
	(0.016)	(0.016)
Media	0.320***	0.262***
	(0.027)	(0.025)
Year Fixed Effect	✓	✓
Author Fixed Effect	✓	✓
Topic Fixed Effect	✓	✓
Sentiment Control	✓	✓
Observations	126,674	126,674

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS estimates on exact-matched data. The dependent variables are log-transformed like and retweet counts. All models include year, author, and topic fixed effects and sentiment controls. Standard errors clustered by matched subclass in parentheses.

One concern is that our dictionary measure captures any AI mention, conflating tweets in which

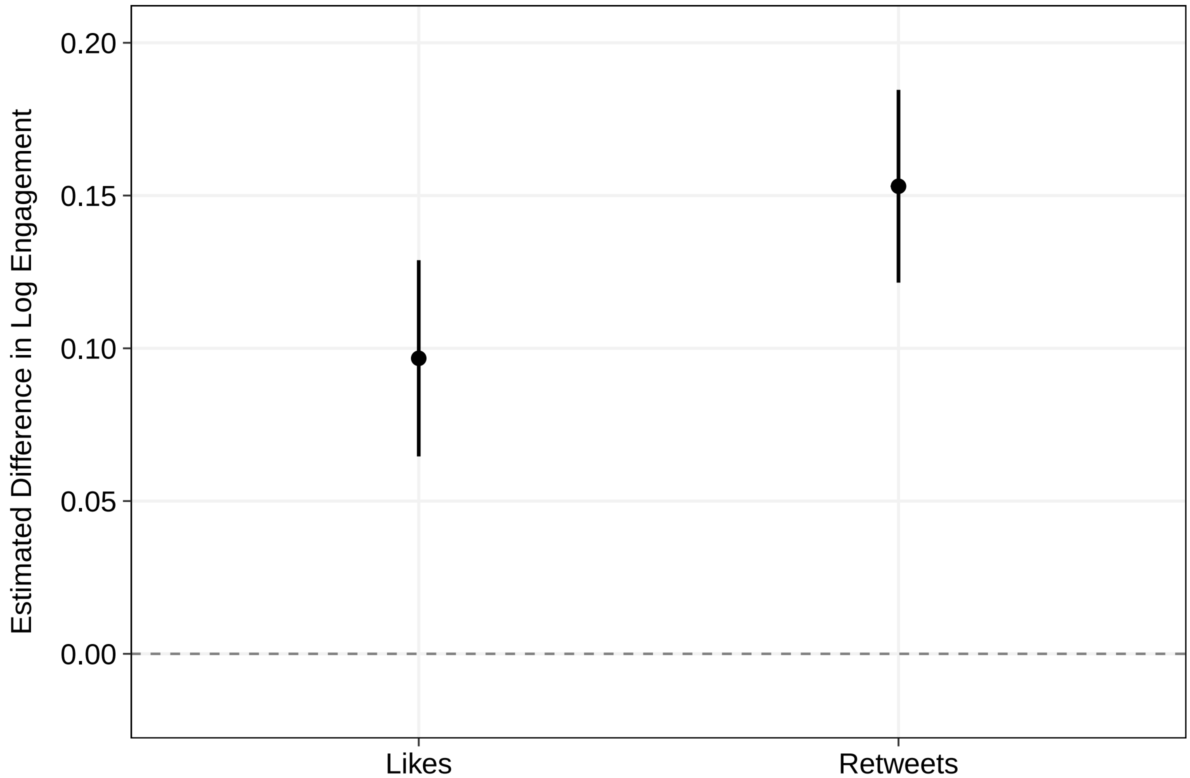

Figure 6: **Marginal Effect of AI Mention on Tweet Engagement.** Points represent the average marginal effect of mentioning AI on log likes and log retweets, estimated using linear regression models on exact-matched data. Whiskers denote 95% confidence intervals based on standard errors clustered by matched subclass.

the IO describes its own operational use of AI with tweets that merely discuss AI or share AI-related news. Legitimacy concerns around opacity, bias, and accountability may arise specifically from the operational use of AI, and one might worry that engagement effects are driven by advocacy or informational tweets rather than the construct our theory specifies. To examine this, we use a large language model to classify AI tweets into three categories: *Operational* (the IO is itself using or deploying AI in its own activities or decision-making), *Advocacy* (the IO makes normative claims about how AI should be governed or regulated by others), or *Informational* (the IO discusses AI as a general phenomenon without operational or normative stakes), and rerun our analysis separately by category. See Appendix Section 1.3 for the full classification prompt.

Results are reported in Appendix Table A5, with the marginal effects by category located in

Appendix Figure A5. We find that the engagement premium is largest for *Operational* tweets, where coefficients reach 0.196 for likes and 0.195 for retweets, and attenuates for *Advocacy* and *Informational* tweets. The variation across AI categories provides additional confidence that our main finding reflects public response to IO AI adoption specifically, rather than broad interest in AI as a general topic. Paired with the survey experiment, these results are consistent with the attention–legitimacy tradeoff we theorize, suggesting that the same technology that attracts public attention may simultaneously undermine public trust in IOs.

Conclusion

International organizations increasingly face a dual political challenge. They must remain visible and relevant in a crowded and contested public sphere, yet they must also preserve the legitimacy needed to sustain support for their authority and activities. This paper has argued that artificial intelligence exacerbates this tension. On the one hand, AI offers IOs a powerful signal of innovation and modernity. On the other hand, it can trigger public concerns about bias and weak accountability. The result is an attention-legitimacy tradeoff, where AI may help IOs attract notice and engagement even as it undermines trust. We evaluated this argument with two forms of evidence. First, our original survey experiment shows that publics are less supportive of IOs when those organizations emphasize their use of AI. Second, our analysis of IO social media communication shows that posts referencing AI receive greater engagement than comparable posts that do not. These findings suggest that AI makes IOs more salient without making them more trusted.

Our results contribute to current scholarship in several ways. First, they add to work on IO legitimacy by showing that emerging technologies can reshape how publics evaluate global governance. Existing research emphasizes that IO legitimacy depends not only on whether organizations appear effective, but also on whether they appear transparent and accountable. Our results suggest that AI cuts across those dimensions by signaling competence and problem-solving capacity, but also impartiality and opacity. Second, the paper contributes to research on technology and global governance by shifting attention from the adoption and regulation of AI to public reactions. Third, the paper contributes to scholarship on IO communication by demonstrating that public attention can increase even when trust declines.

Our theory also carries implications for practicioners. We show that technological innovation does not automatically generate legitimacy, and indeed can cut against it. Although AI may help IOs become more visible, it can generate backlash as well. IOs may therefore wish to tred cautiously as they adopt and communicate about AI. If they want to benefit from AI's attention gains without sacrificing legitimacy, they may need to emphasize and retain human oversight, transparency, and clear responsibility along with their claims of efficiency.

Our findings suggest several directions for future research. First, scholars could investigate the conditions under which AI's legitimacy costs are reduced or even reversed. Publics may react differently when AI is framed as an advisor rather than autonomous, so that human decision-makers remain in control, or when organizations emphasize transparency and accountability. A second avenue is to connect IO communication about AI to IO relevance and ability to attract funding. Future work could also investigate heterogeneity across institutions and issue areas, as AI may be viewed as more legitimate or attract more attention in some issue areas such as technical or service-delivery contexts, than others like those involving redistribution or security.

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Supporting Information for "AI in Global Governance: The Attention–Legitimacy Tradeoff for International Organizations"

June 19, 2026

*Allison Carnegie is Professor, Columbia University (Email: allison.carnegie@columbia.edu). Seowoo Chung is PhD Candidate, Columbia University. Lisa Fan is postdoctoral researcher, University of Oxford. We received helpful comments from Richard Clark and the participants of virtual APSA. All remaining errors are our own.

Contents

1 Social Media Analysis

IO	Username	Mean	Min	Max
Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank	AIIB_Official	25.118	25.118	25.118
Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation	APEC	94.107	94.107	94.107
African Development Bank Group	AfDB_Group	113.280	113.280	113.280
Asian Development Bank	ADB_HQ	355.848	355.848	355.848
Bank for International Settlements	BIS_org	131.970	131.970	131.970
Global Green Growth Institute	gggi_hq	51.932	51.932	51.932
International Monetary Fund	IMFNews	159.477	159.477	159.477
International Criminal Court	IntlCrimCourt	102.417	102.417	102.417
Inter-American Development Bank	the_IDB	133.348	133.348	133.348
International Energy Agency	IEA	218.636	218.636	218.636
International Labour Organization	ilo	135.288	135.288	135.288
International Telecommunication Union	ITU	107.098	107.098	107.098
Islamic Development Bank Group	isdb_group	82.186	82.186	82.186
North Atlantic Treaty Organization	NATO	108.833	108.833	108.833
New Development Bank	NDB_int	35.115	35.115	35.115
Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development	OECD	134.030	134.030	134.030

Organisation of Eastern Caribbean States	oecscommission	57.344	57.344	57.344
Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries	OPECSecretariat	68.085	68.085	68.085
European Bank for Reconstruction and Development	EBRD	361.841	361.841	361.841
United Nations Industrial Development Organization	UNIDO	295.295	295.295	295.295
World Trade Organization	wto	177.260	177.260	177.260
World Bank	WorldBank	364.000	364.000	364.000
World Health Organization	WHO	520.977	520.977	520.977

Table A1: **Twitter Sample.** *Mean*, *Min*, and *Max* refer to the average, minimum and maximum number of tweets issued by an IO in a given month-year.

1.1 Dictionary Approach

Dictionary	Key Terms
AI	artificial intelligence, AI, machine learning, robots, robotics, advanced technology, new technology, digital technology, disruptive technology, emerging technology, breakthrough technology, innovative technology, big data, 3d printing, three-dimensional printing, blockchain, the cloud, cloud computing, cryptography, crypto, big tech, fintech, deep learning, neural networks, algorithms, algorithmic bias, data mining, natural language processing, data science, image recognition

Table A2: **AI Dictionary.** Key terms include plural and singular forms of words.

IO	Example Tweet
AIIB	From introducing #solarpower into vaccine logistics chains, to tapping digital platforms and #AI to train health workers around the world; AIIB's @ErikBerglof outlines the opportunity for ambitious international initiatives to improve global health-system #resilience. #I4T
	New #infrastructure is essential for AI technologies to work. Simultaneously, #AI can help retool traditional infrastructure - roads, electricity, etc, making it #sustainable. E.g.: What sensors will roads need today to accommodate autonomous vehicles of the future? @kaifulee
ADB	Find out how developing Asia can embrace artificial intelligence and satellite imagery to generate more granular poverty data. Read the @adbpublications
	New technologies such as artificial intelligence can help deliver basic services to the public. This @DevelopmentAsia explainer details how governments and non-government organizations can make the shift: https://t.co/6blt3Jtd8e
	As advances in #artificialintelligence and #automation continue, the distance between high-skilled elites and everyone else will only grow. New technologies can be used to close the #educationgap https://t.co/PxcmlpLWnu via @ProSyn
OECD	What is the environmental footprint of artificial intelligence? This panel event will launch our new report, "The AI footprint: measuring the environmental impacts of AI compute and applications". 15 November 5:00 PM – 6:15 PM (EET) https://t.co/P7u31O6Ovj
	The potential impacts of #ArtificialIntelligence call for open dialogue. Join us online today at 13:45 CET as experts from #OECD stakeholder partners discuss the future of #AI, its implications & the #AIpolicy priorities for their communities https://t.co/rLO70gqNJz #OECDAI https://t.co/cZYWlFVb2T

	OECD #AI Principles promote #ArtificialIntelligence that is trustworthy & human-centric. The #OECDAI platform enables the implementation of the Principles & gives access to live data, policies & initiatives of Member countries. https://t.co/nRrelgjR4y #OECDMinisterial https://t.co/H1oYXBTBcm
World Bank	Is artificial intelligence the future for #economicdevelopment? A group of @WorldBank staff, academic researchers, & technology company representatives met at a conference in #SanFrancisco to discuss new advances in #artificialintelligence. https://t.co/vyJweL0c8X #AI https://t.co/0mh5lPuuXM
	What's next for the digital revolution? @SEDIAgob's @carmeartigas explains how developing countries can leverage #BigData, AI, and open innovation to improve productivity and efficiency as they look to the future. Tune in to watch here: https://t.co/fKAHgAIC1Z #PowerOfDigital https://t.co/ZdB4hKL59P
	Can Artificial Intelligence help governments improve the lives of citizens? UAE's Minister of Artificial Intelligence is showing the way. Take part in the conversation: https://t.co/NKtYzuMH9y #DigitalDev https://t.co/IaLYnyZzSr
WTO	.@SusanLund_DC on the impact of automation: 65% of the remaining jobs in the manufacturing industry could be replaced by robotics and IA. Companies such as Adidas and Nike have now shoes that can be done entirely by robots. #WTOPublicForum2018 #Tech4Trade
	Happening now at the #WTOPublicForum, "AI in the Post-COVID Economic Recovery: Is it Worth the Incentives of Intellectual Property Rights?" session with @RealSophiaRobot , @hansonrobotics, @LawTechGadget, Luca Rinaldi & @sharma_kriti

	AI is on the agenda at the #WTOPublicForum.Meet speaker @RealSophiaRobot.Here she apologizes for interrupting @DavidHanson.Later, this convo happened: I'm expensive. And worth it. https://t.co/GF1N0azm08
IMF	What countries stand to gain most from #AI #robots? @imf_podcast https://t.co/un7MUz8Vul https://t.co/HRmAQ9Xx52
	Artificial Intelligence could cause a growing divergence between rich and poor countries. Policymakers in developing economies will need to take actions to raise productivity and improve skills. Read more on #IMFBlog: https://t.co/uAlyzmcDYu #AI https://t.co/foYklcVJ7Q
	Japan's combination of artificial intelligence (#ai) and #robotics may be the answer to its rapidly shrinking labor force, but what does that mean for the future of work? Our June 2018 issue of Finance & Development magazine goes in-depth https://t.co/z6apaXRZ44 https://t.co/IcuETCq4qN
BIS	Central banks are setting up platforms for #BigData analytics and #ArtificialIntelligence. What is their experience so far? What are the lessons & the challenges? The Irving Fisher Committee on Central Bank Statistics takes stock @bancaditalia https://t.co/E64uh1806R https://t.co/ZEx9cniwZA
	Existing #RegulatoryRequirements on governance and #RiskManagement related to #ArtificialIntelligence and #MachineLearning use cases in finance need to place a stronger emphasis on human oversight to avoid discriminatory and unethical results https://t.co/1apNgN7HKv https://t.co/5towrCkv0J
	#BaselCommittee newsletter highlights how banks are exploring opportunities for using artificial intelligence and machine learning to improve risk management, but there are also risks and challenges #AI #ML https://t.co/6bnosrxgaP https://t.co/386sN0pP6v

ITU	Synchronization is more important than ever and will be even more so in future mobile networks to support time-sensitive networking for automated vehicles or controlling robots in smart factories. @ITUstandards are key to such ambitions. https://t.co/k3iY55PvpS
	Explore the benefits + advantages of cities adopting #AI to improve their services and enhance efficiency, with real-world cases of successful implementation in this #DigitalTransformation webinar! 23 November, 14:00 CET https://t.co/RRYmdsdxdZ https://t.co/X8QLAjvyyj
	How #crowdsourcing data and #AI strengthen disaster management https://t.co/FGEzYYy8MA #AIforGood https://t.co/nUvxk0PRx7

Table A3: **Example AI Tweets by IOs.** Tweets that include mentions of AI-related terms.

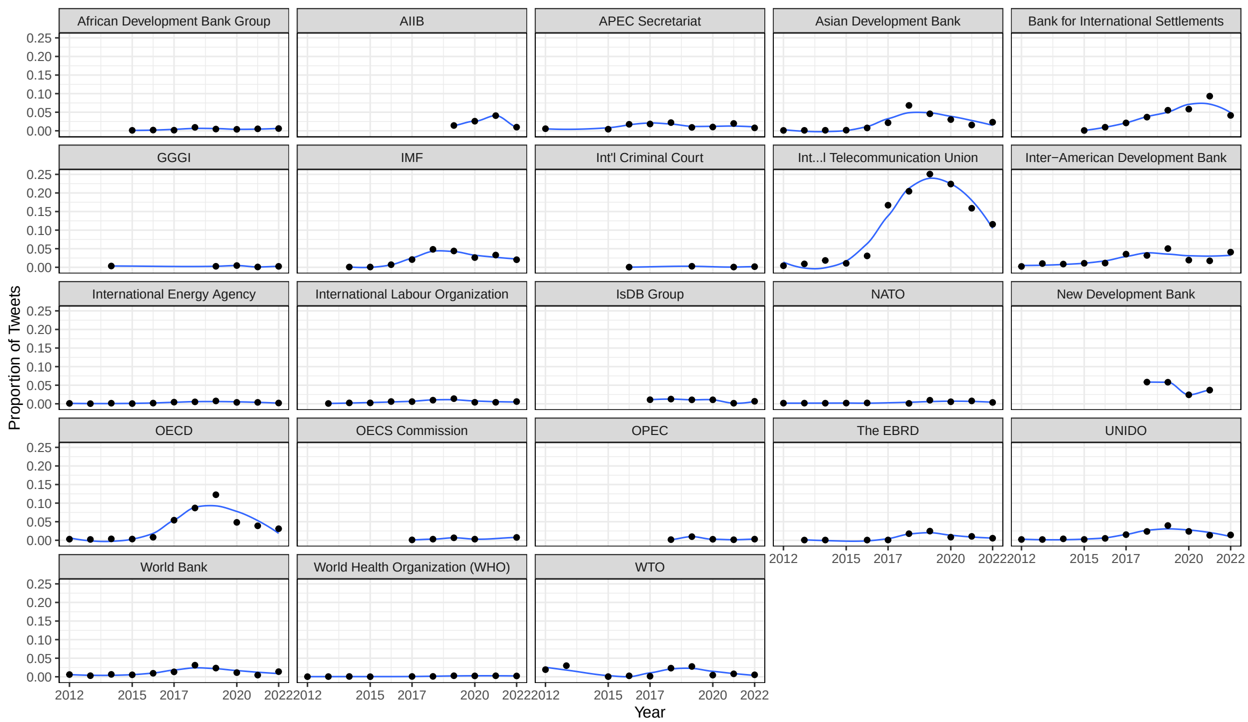

Figure A1: **Proportion of AI Tweets by IO.** Share of tweets that mention AI issued by IOs in a given year.

1.2 Matching Tweets

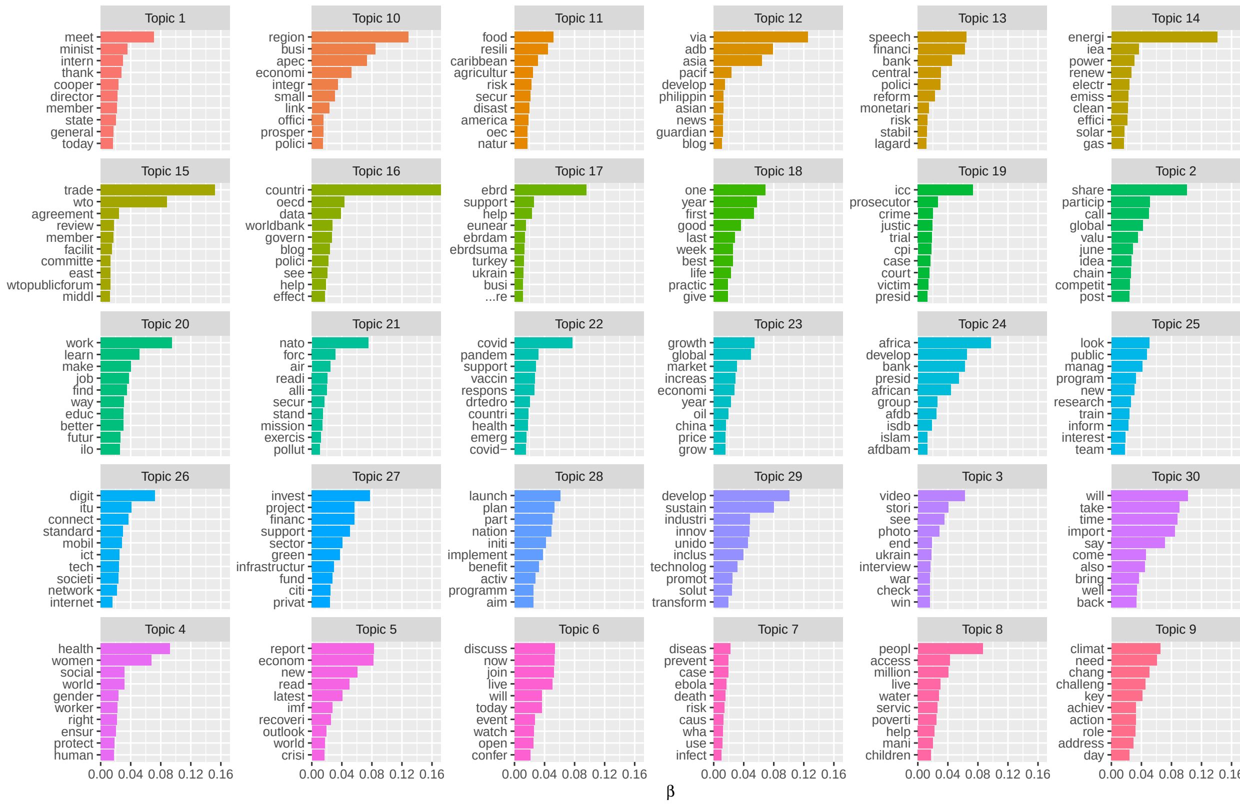

Figure A2: **Top 30 Topics from IO Tweets.** Top 30 topics and their associated words. β denotes predicted probabilities of the word associated with each topic. Results from Structural Topic Model (STM).

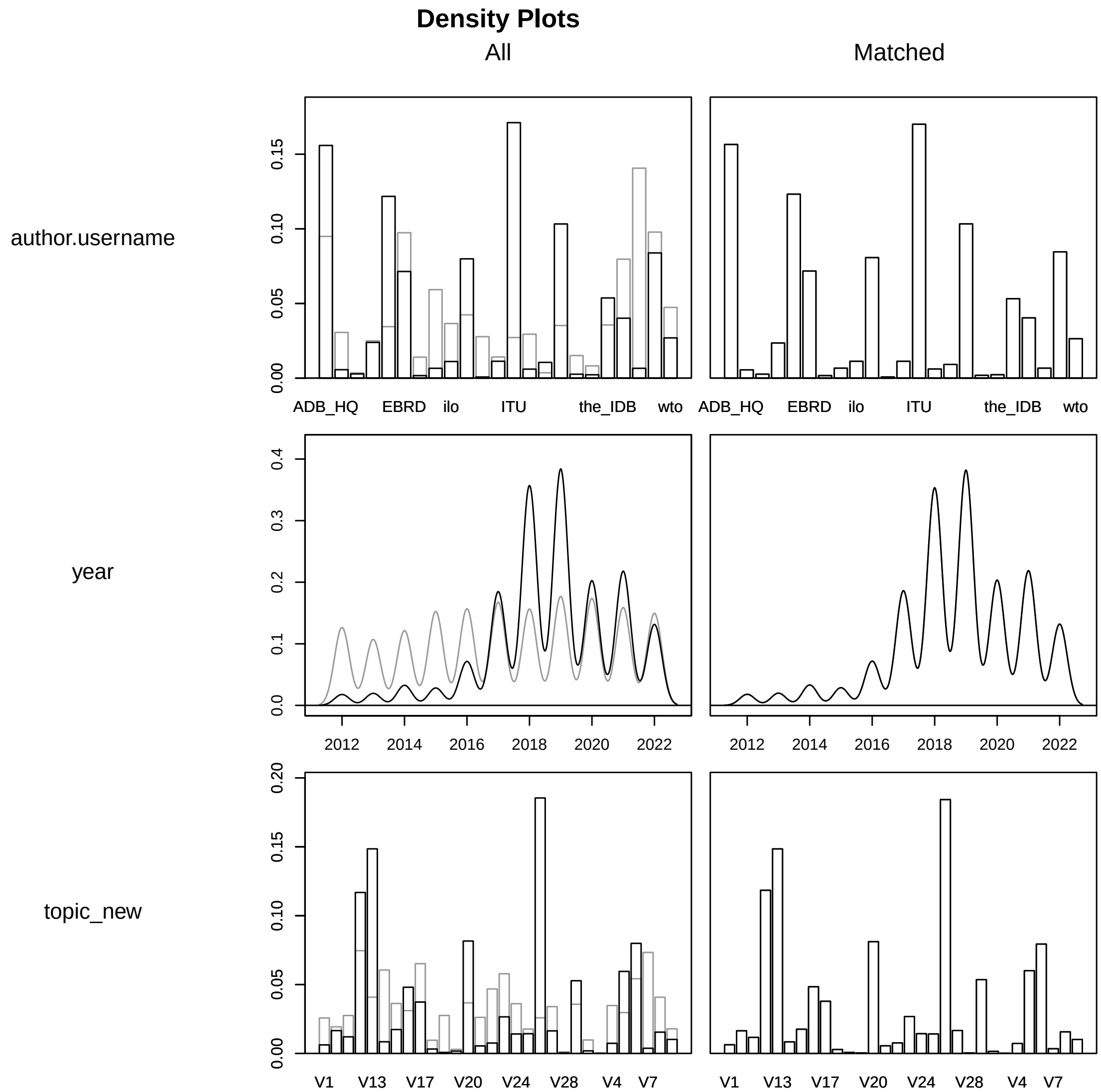

Figure A3: **Density Plots to Assess Balance.** X-axis displays covariate values and y-axis shows the density of the sample at that specific value (proportion of sample at that covariate value). Black line corresponds to 'treated' group and gray line to the control group. Lines that overlap perfectly indicate good balance.

1.3 LLM Prompt

LLM classification was performed using Claude Haiku (claude-haiku-4-5-20251001) via the Anthropic API, with a retry limit of 5 and exponential backoff on rate-limit errors.

```
You are classifying tweets from international organizations (IOs) based on
how they discuss artificial intelligence (AI).

Classify each tweet into one of three categories:

- OPERATIONAL:  The IO is itself using, deploying, or developing AI as
part of its own activities or decision-making processes.  Examples:  using
machine learning to predict outcomes, deploying AI tools for internal
analysis, automating workflows, using AI to generate recommendations or
forecasts.

- ADVOCACY:  The IO is making normative claims about how AI should
be governed, regulated, or used by others.  Examples:  publishing AI
principles, calling for AI regulation, hosting panels on AI ethics,
endorsing AI governance frameworks, discussing AI policy.

- INFORMATIONAL:  The IO is discussing AI as a general phenomenon, sharing
news, or commenting on AI trends in society without operational or normative
stakes.  Examples:  sharing AI research findings, commenting on AI industry
trends, retweeting AI news.

# Output format:

{
  "category":  "OPERATIONAL" or "ADVOCACY" or "INFORMATIONAL",
  "justification":  "one sentence explaining the classification"
}
```

1.4 Alternative Specifications

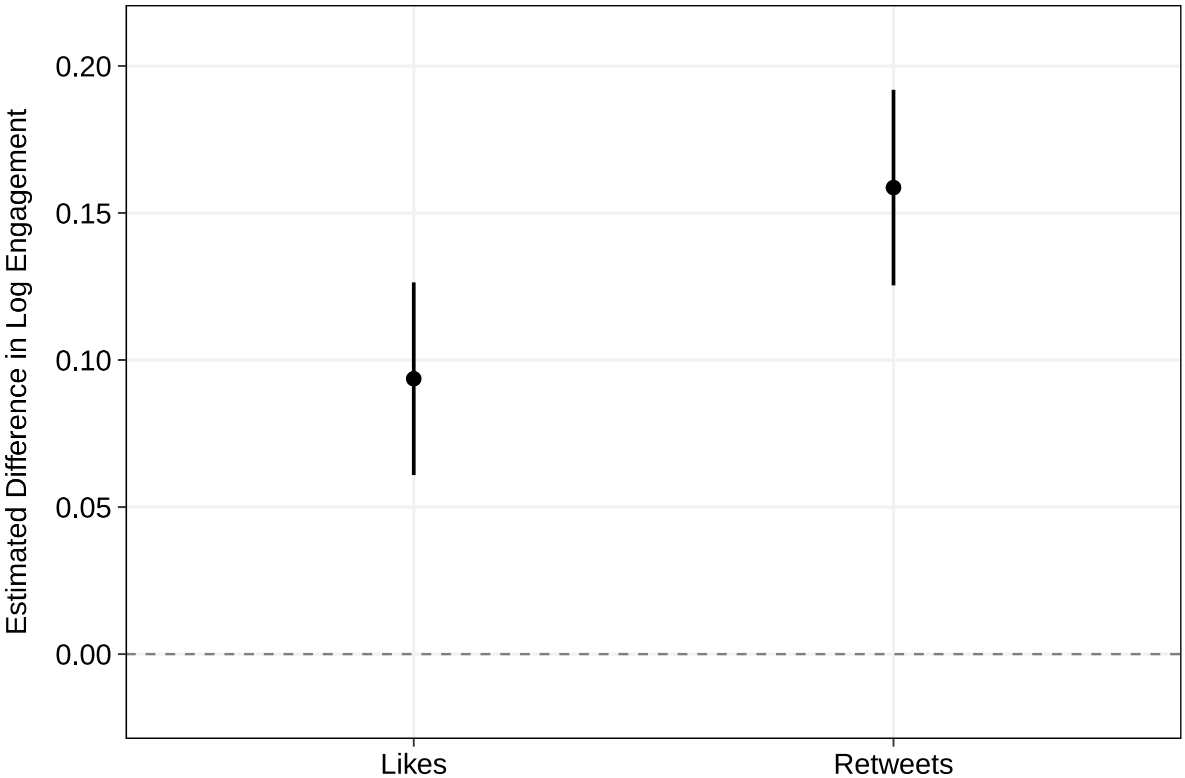

Figure A4: **Marginal Effect of AI Mention on Tweet Engagement, Month-Year.** Average marginal effects from OLS regression on exact-matched data with month-year fixed effects. Whiskers denote 95% confidence intervals with standard errors clustered by matched subclass.

Table A4: Robustness: Month-Year Fixed Effects (Exact-Matched Sample)

	Log (Likes)	Log (Retweets)
AI Mention	0.094***	0.159***
	(0.017)	(0.017)
Media	0.235***	0.242***
	(0.031)	(0.029)
Month-Year Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Author Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Topic Fixed Effects	✓	✓
Sentiment Control	✓	✓
Observations	35,656	35,656

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS estimates on exact-matched data, replicating the main specification but replacing year fixed effects with month-year fixed effects to account for finer-grained temporal trends. The dependent variables are log-transformed like and retweet counts. All models include author and topic fixed effects and sentiment controls. Standard errors clustered by matched subclass in parentheses.

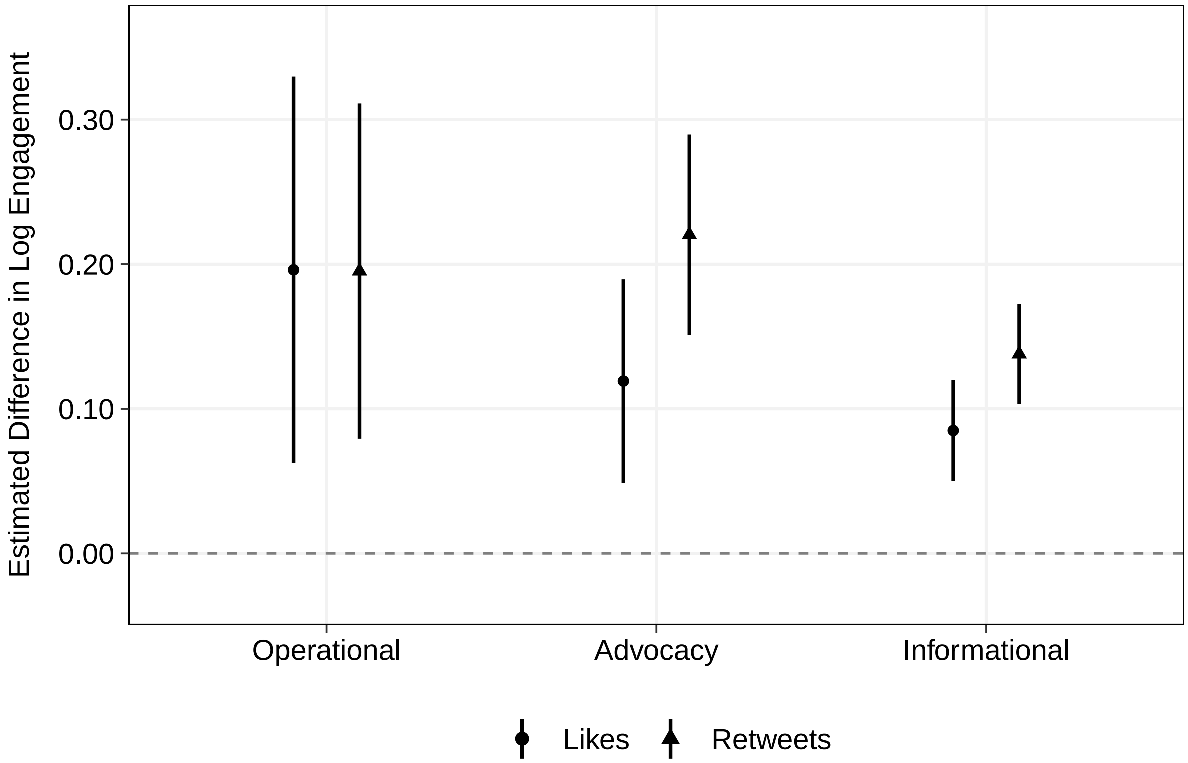

Figure A5: **Marginal Effect of AI Mention by Tweet Type.** Average marginal effects of mentioning AI on log likes and log retweets, estimated separately for *Operational*, *Advocacy*, and *Informational* AI tweets relative to matched non-AI tweets. Whiskers denote 95% confidence intervals with standard errors clustered by matched subclass.

Table A5: OLS Models by AI Tweet Type (Exact-Matched Sample)

	Operational		Advocacy		Informational	
	Likes	Retweets	Likes	Retweets	Likes	Retweets
AI Mention	0.196***	0.195***	0.119***	0.220***	0.085***	0.138***
	(0.068)	(0.059)	(0.036)	(0.035)	(0.018)	(0.018)
Media	0.305***	0.242***	0.317***	0.242***	0.325***	0.278***
	(0.074)	(0.064)	(0.062)	(0.053)	(0.028)	(0.025)
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Author FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Topic FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Sentiment controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	22,286	22,286	28,556	28,556	113,991	113,991

* $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Notes: OLS estimates on exact-matched data. Each column reports a separate model matching tweets of the indicated AI category as classified by the LLM (*Operational, Advocacy, or Informational*) against non-AI tweets. The dependent variables are log-transformed like and retweet counts. All models include year, author, and topic fixed effects and sentiment controls. Standard errors clustered by matched subclass in parentheses.